Foreign Exchange (SAFE) said that it was “actively” considering buying as much as $50 billion of IMF bonds, the Bank of Russia announced it would sell some of its $140 billion of U.S. Treasuries to purchase IMF bonds. India similarly announced that it would be “perfectly capable of contributing” to the IMF’s bond program, while Brazil’s Finance Minister Guido Mantega, in Brasília, emphasized that the IMF debt denominated in SDRs would pay a similar yield to U.S. Treasuries. Although shifting from dollar holdings to SDRs was still largely an investment in the dollar (then 44% of the SDR), it was an important signal that the BRICS wanted to increase their voice in international financial institutions.[44]

In a remarkable turnaround, prior to the 2009 London G20 summit U.S. Treasury Secretary Timothy Geithner requested to meet with the BRICs quartet, as they discussed whether and how to contribute to the IMF. A Russian delegation source told reporters, “The voice of the BRICs has grown stronger, and proof of that is that U.S. finance minister Geithner has asked to come to the BRIC meeting and to discuss a range of issues.”[45] However, progress was still slow, and a year later, the BRICS were still trying to get a firm commitment to increase their representation in the IMF. Prior to the G20 summit in South Korea in October 2010, there was another opportunity for G7 countries to negotiate with the BRICS. The result was a breakthrough that helped conclude the 2010 package of quota reforms, though these still had to be ratified by the parties, especially the United States, which was the veto holder. According to Eswar Prasad, a former IMF official and professor at Cornell University who has close ties to Chinese and Indian officials, the BRICs wanted to send a “double message”—that they “are willing to contribute to the IMF, but they won’t contribute heavily to longer-term fund resources until the world body increases their voting shares substantially.” Prasad added, “They don’t want to get locked into providing more money until they get their [shares] increased.”[46]

Subsequently, in 2012, before the Los Cabos G20 summit, the BRICS affirmed their commitment to help provide a financial safety net. The financial and economic crisis in the West and demand for financial resources had a silver lining for the BRICs countries. It marked a major step toward perceived multipolarity and also raised questions about whether the United States and the G7 countries were “responsible” stewards, while leaving no doubt that the BRICS were increasingly major stakeholders in the existing order.[47]